

PAGE 1 — COVER

Title: HVAC Repair Quote Negotiation Subtitle: Don't Get Ripped Off — The Homeowner's Field Guide to Fair HVAC Pricing Audience tag: For homeowners facing HVAC/AC repair estimates Tagline: 10-page guide

PAGE 2 — INTRODUCTION

Hook: You wake up on a Tuesday morning in August. Your AC is blowing warm air. You call the first company that shows up in Google. They spend 20 minutes in your utility closet and come out with a quote: \$4,700. "You need a new compressor and fan." You don't know what that means. You don't know if the price is fair. You feel pressure to say yes because it's August and you have kids and it is hot. This guide exists because this exact scenario happens thousands of times a year to homeowners who don't speak HVAC.

The raw frustration: A homeowner in r/HomeImprovement wrote: "Quoted almost \$10,000 for a \$150 HVAC repair job. How do you know what's actually fair?" The most upvoted reply was: "Get three more bids. Immediately."

What this guide does: It gives you a line-item breakdown of what HVAC repairs actually cost, a script for getting competitive quotes, your legal rights as a consumer, and a checklist you can run through in 48 hours. When you finish page 10, you'll know what the repair should cost, how to verify the contractor's work, and what to do if you've already signed something you regret.

PAGE 3 — THE ESTIMATE AUDIT

Body: The first thing you need to do is get every HVAC estimate in writing as a line-item breakdown. Not just a total. A line-item. Every bid should break down: labor cost, parts cost, markup on parts, and any added fees. If a company refuses to itemize, do not hire them. The "orange bag test": if you can't see inside, you don't know what you're paying for. The same principle applies to HVAC estimates.

Common HVAC Components and Fair Price Ranges: - Refrigerant R-410A: \$75–\$150 per pound. Most residential systems need 5-15 lbs. Total material cost: \$375–\$2,250, installed. - Run/start capacitor: \$30–\$80 for the part. Labor to replace: 15-30 minutes. Fair total: \$90–\$200. - Contactor (the switch that turns the compressor on): \$20–\$50 for the part. Labor: 20-45 minutes. Fair total: \$75–\$180. - Blower motor: \$200–\$600 for the part. Labor: 1-2 hours. Fair total: \$350–\$900. - Compressor (the heart of the system):

\$800–\$2,500 for the part. Labor: 3-6 hours. Fair total: \$1,500–\$4,000 installed. - Fan motor: \$150–\$400. Labor: 1-2 hours. Fair total: \$350–\$700.

The Repair vs. Replace Decision Tree: Ask: How old is your system? If it's under 10 years old and the repair is under \$2,000: repair. If it's over 12 years old and the repair is over \$1,500: look at replacement quotes side by side. If it's over 15 years old: get a second opinion on whether repair makes sense at all.

PAGE 4 — PILLAR 1 DEEP DIVE: HOW TO READ ESTIMATES AND SPOT INFLATION

Body: Quote inflation happens in a few predictable ways. The most common: bundling. A company says "you need a new compressor" but when you get the line-item breakdown, they charged you for a new compressor, a new fan, AND a new contactor — all done on the same service call. Sometimes that's legitimate. Often it's padding.

The "Same-Visit Upsell": Technician says "while I'm here, you should also replace X." Legitimate emergency upsells happen. But when a technician finds three additional issues in one visit, that warrants a separate diagnostic session — not an immediate on-the-spot decision.

How to verify part numbers: Every HVAC component has a model number printed on the unit. Take a photo of the nameplate (usually a silver label on the side of the outdoor unit) and search the part number on Google. Sites like SupplyHouse.com, REIActors, and Amazon list actual retail prices for parts. If the company's part markup is more than 40% above retail, that's a red flag.

The "York/Trane/Carrier" test: If a company tells you that you MUST use their brand's parts ("we can only install OEM parts"), they're allowed to prefer that, but they're not allowed to charge you whatever they want for it. Get the part number and look it up independently.

PAGE 5 — THE COMPETITIVE QUOTE PROCESS

Body: The 72-hour rule: never commit on the same day you receive a quote. This is a control mechanism for you, not for them. "I need 72 hours to review the estimate and compare options" is a reasonable, normal thing to say. Any contractor who pressures you to sign immediately — "today's price," "my schedule fills up," "I can only hold this for 24 hours" — is using urgency as a weapon, and you should take your business elsewhere.

The 5 Questions to Ask Before Scheduling: 1. Are you licensed in [your state]? Can you give me your license number? 2. Do you charge a diagnostic fee? Is that applied to the

repair if we move forward? 3. Do you provide a written, line-item estimate before starting work? 4. Who performs the work — your employees or a subcontractor? 5. What warranties do you offer on labor and parts?

The Competitive Quote Script: Call 3 companies. Tell each one the same thing: "I've received a quote for [specific problem] and I'm looking for a second opinion. I'm getting two more bids before deciding." Watch how they respond. Companies that deflect ("you should just go with the first quote"), badmouth competitors, or pressure you for an immediate appointment are companies you should not hire.

PAGE 6 — PILLAR 2 DEEP DIVE: HOW TO FIND THREE LICENSED CONTRACTORS IN 24 HOURS

Body: Most homeowners don't have a contractor network. Here's how to build one fast.

Step 1 — Angie's List/HomeAdvisor filter: Both platforms have a "licensed HVAC contractor" filter. Set it to your zip code, filter for central air conditioning, minimum 5-star rating with 10+ reviews. Call the top 3.

Step 2 — Neighborhood Facebook Groups and Nextdoor: Post: "Looking for HVAC company recommendations in [zip code]. Had a bad experience with [company]. Want someone licensed and transparent." The local recommendations in these groups are better than Google ads because they're from real homeowners.

Step 3 — Your city/county contractor licensing board website. Most states publish a public database of licensed HVAC contractors by zip code. This is free. Use it. A contractor without a current license in your state is not someone you want in your house.

Step 4 — Yelp with the "not recommended" filter: Read 1-star reviews carefully. If a company has multiple reviews citing "surprise charges," "wouldn't give me an estimate," or "pressured me to sign," that is signal. Move on.

PAGE 7 — KNOW YOUR RIGHTS

Body: You have more legal protection than you think. Most homeowners don't know these rights until they need them.

The FTC Cooling-Off Rule: If a contractor knocked on your door and you signed a contract there, you have 3 business days to cancel it — in writing. This is federal law (FTC Rule 312). It applies to door-to-door sales of \$25 or more. Most HVAC emergency

calls qualify. If you signed something at your door in the last 72 hours, you may still be able to cancel.

State HVAC Licensing Boards: Every state has a contractor licensing board. You can search by company name or license number. If a company is not licensed in your state, they technically cannot perform the work — and if something goes wrong, you have no recourse. The board website is free to search. Use it.

When to Call a City Inspector: In most jurisdictions, any work involving refrigerants (the chemical that makes your AC cool) requires a city inspection. If a company tells you they don't need to pull a permit because "it's a small job," they may be trying to avoid inspection. Ask: "Will you pull a permit for this work? Who is the responsible licensed master?"

BBB Complaint Process: Before filing, call the company directly and give them 5 business days to respond to your complaint. If they don't respond or refuse to correct the issue, file with the BBB. Companies that rely on local reviews care about their BBB rating. A formal complaint is a slow-moving but real consequence for dishonest contractors.

PAGE 8 — PILLAR 3 DEEP DIVE: IF YOU'VE ALREADY SIGNED SOMETHING

Body: It happens. The AC went out, the company came fast, you felt pressured, you signed. Here's what you can actually do.

If you signed a contract at a door: Use the FTC cooling-off rule within 3 business days. In writing. Email is fine if the contract doesn't specify certified mail. Keep a copy.

If you've already paid money upfront: Document everything. Photos of work done (if any), receipts, contracts, all correspondence. If the company performed no work and won't refund, small claims court is an option for amounts under your state's limit (typically \$3,000–\$10,000 depending on state). Filing is often available online.

If the company did work that's faulty: Contact your state licensing board. In most states, the board can investigate and potentially revoke the contractor's license. That's a more serious consequence than a BBB complaint.

If your deposit was taken and the company ghosted: The credit card chargeback process is an option if you paid by card. Contact your bank within 120 days of the transaction.

PAGE 9 — QUICK-REFERENCE CHECKLIST

Title: Quote Comparison Checklist — One Page at a Glance

Before the Visit: ☐ 3 companies identified via licensing board database ☐ Diagnostic fee asked upfront (\$50–\$150 is normal; \$0 if applied to repair) ☐ 5 questions prepared for each company

During the Estimate: ☐ Written, line-item estimate requested ☐ Part numbers photographed from the unit ☐ Repair vs. replace question answered ☐ Permit question asked: "Will you pull a permit?"

After the Estimate: ☐ Each estimate itemized ☐ Part numbers checked against retail pricing ☐ 72-hour hold confirmed (no same-day commitment) ☐ Company license verified on state licensing board ☐ References called (if repair is over \$500)

If Something Went Wrong: ☐ FTC cooling-off calculation: days since signature? ☐ State licensing board search: license verified? ☐ City inspector called if refrigerant work was done without permit ☐ BBB complaint drafted (if applicable)

PAGE 10 — NEXT STEPS

Title: Your Bonus Subtitle: Included

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Your Next Steps: ☐ Get the full guide — Lemon Squeezy link ☐ Member's Area — for existing customers access